

[DOWNLOADABLE CHECKLIST](#)

The CRM Governance SOP Template

By Tejas Dhabalia, Co-founder, DS Consulting | consult-ds.com

A practitioner checklist for teams who are done with dirty data, broken dashboards, and pipeline numbers that do not match reality.

Why I built this

I have spent the better part of fifteen years inside marketing ops and RevOps functions at Deloitte, Tesco, Tata, and Godrej. The single most consistent failure I saw was not tool selection. It was governance. Teams would buy Salesforce, HubSpot, or Dynamics, spend six months configuring it, and then watch it degrade within a year because nobody owned the data model, nobody controlled field creation, and nobody could agree on what a qualified lead actually meant.

Recent IBM's 2025-2026 research shows that poor data quality is still a major commercial risk. IBM says more than a quarter of organisations now estimate annual losses of over USD 5 million from poor data quality, while Salesforce reports that siloed systems and poor data quality remain the top barriers to AI-driven personalisation. At the execution level, only one in four marketers are satisfied with how they use data for personalised engagement, and Validity found that 76% of CRM users say less than half of their CRM data is accurate and complete. This checklist is the operating model I use when I start a CRM governance engagement. It is the minimum you need to stop the bleeding and build something sustainable.

SECTION 1: DATA MODEL AND TAXONOMY

Ownership and definitions

- ☐ **Define a single owner for each core object: Lead, Contact, Account, Opportunity.**
Owner is accountable for field standards, required fields, and data quality - not just admin access.
- ☐ **Publish a field glossary with approved definitions for all fields used in reporting.**
Include: field name, object, definition, who populates it, and acceptable values.
- ☐ **Agree on a single written definition of 'qualified lead' across marketing, sales, and RevOps.**
Store it in the CRM description field and your internal wiki. If it is not written down, it does not exist.
- ☐ **Set required fields at each lifecycle stage transition.**
A lead should not be able to move to MQL without meeting defined criteria. Enforce this in the platform.
- ☐ **Document and enforce a naming convention for all custom fields.**
Example: [Team]_[Category]_[Descriptor]. Enforce before any new field is created, not retroactively.

Duplicate and identity management

- ☐ **Define the primary identifier for deduplication: email, domain, phone, or a combination.**
Document the merge rules: which record wins and which fields are preserved.

- ☐ **Implement a deduplication rule that runs on record creation, not just on import.**
Reactive dedup alone will never keep pace with inbound volume.
- ☐ **Map the identity resolution logic between CRM, MAP, and your finance system.**
A customer who exists in three systems needs a consistent identifier in all three.
- ☐ **Set a deduplication review cadence - at minimum quarterly.**
Assign ownership. Without a named owner, this will not happen.

SECTION 2: LIFECYCLE STAGE GOVERNANCE

- ☐ **Document every lifecycle stage with entry criteria, exit criteria, and an SLA.**
Entry: what must be true to enter. Exit: what triggers movement. SLA: how long a record can sit before escalation.
- ☐ **Implement automated stage-move rules where the criteria are objective.**
Manual stage movement is the leading cause of stage drift and reporting unreliability.
- ☐ **Define what happens to a record when it fails to progress past SLA.**
Recycle to nurture, reassign, or disqualify - documented, automated, and owned.
- ☐ **Set up a weekly stage health report showing volume, velocity, and SLA adherence by stage.**
Must go to the revenue team automatically. If it requires manual assembly, it will not survive.
- ☐ **Document lead routing rules by geography, segment, account size, and product line.**
Routing exceptions must also be documented. Unrouted leads are invisible leads.
- ☐ **Document what happens to leads from events, inbound chat, and partner channels.**
These are the most common sources of routing gaps.

SECTION 3: CHANGE CONTROL

This is the section most teams skip. It is also the section whose absence causes the most damage.

- ☐ **No new custom field created without a written request stating the business use case.**
Include: requestor, use case, reporting dependency, field owner, and approval sign-off.
- ☐ **All workflow and automation changes logged in a change register before deployment to production.**
Log: description, expected impact, deployment date, owner, and rollback plan.
- ☐ **A sandbox environment exists and all changes are tested there before production.**
Zero-day production changes are not acceptable for any workflow touching revenue data.
- ☐ **A quarterly audit of unused fields, inactive workflows, and orphaned records.**
CRM entropy compounds. Without scheduled cleanup, technical debt becomes a migration project.
- ☐ **A named admin owns the CRM change control process.**
This does not require a full-time role. It requires a named, accountable person.

SECTION 4: MEASUREMENT AND REPORTING GOVERNANCE

- ☐ **Publish a single metric definition document that all teams sign off on.**
Include: MQL, SQL, Win Rate, CAC, LTV, Churn - and the exact CRM logic behind each.
- ☐ **All executive dashboards source from the same CRM reports, not manual exports.**
If the CEO's number differs from the CRO's, you have a governance problem, not a data problem.
- ☐ **Lock the definition of conversion rates: numerator, denominator, time window, and filters.**
A conversion rate without a locked definition is an opinion.
- ☐ **Set up a report validation process before reports go to leadership.**
Fifteen minutes of review prevents hours of crisis management.
- ☐ **Finance and CRM pipeline reconciliation happens monthly, not quarterly.**
The further apart these reconciliations happen, the larger the discrepancy becomes.
- ☐ **All attribution rules are documented, versioned, and approved before any model change.**
Changing attribution methodology mid-year makes all historical comparison invalid.

SECTION 5: INTEGRATIONS AND DATA FLOWS

- ☐ **Document every integration: source system, destination system, sync frequency, field mapping.**
If you cannot draw a complete data flow diagram in 30 minutes, you lack enough documentation.
- ☐ **Identify the system of record for each data type: contact, account, deal.**
Two systems cannot both be the source of truth for the same field.
- ☐ **Set up integration error monitoring with named ownership and a response SLA.**
Silent sync failures are the most dangerous category of data quality problem.
- ☐ **All integration changes go through the same change control process as CRM changes.**
An undocumented integration change can corrupt months of data before anyone notices.
- ☐ **Map the data flow from web form to CRM to MAP to finance for your top three lead sources.**
Gaps in this map are where leads disappear without anyone knowing.

How to score yourself

Score	Status	What it means
80-100%	Governed	Governance foundations solid. Focus on maintenance and edge cases.
50-79%	At Risk	Visible gaps that will compound. Prioritise Sections 3 and 4 first.
Under 50%	Leaking	Revenue is leaking and you cannot see it. This is the most common state.

If you scored below 60%, the gaps in Sections 3 and 5 have the longest remediation lead times. Start there before investing in new automation or AI capabilities.

What to do next

If you have completed fewer than 60% of this checklist, your CRM is likely costing you revenue through invisible leakage, reporting errors, and team misalignment. Most of these gaps can be addressed in a structured 8 to 12 week engagement without a full platform replacement.

Tejas Dhabalia

Co-founder and Principal Consultant at DS Consulting. He began his career as an IBM mainframe software engineer before spending close to a decade building marketing operations and customer insight capabilities at Tata-Tesco and Nature's Basket. He now advises B2B and regulated-sector clients on CRM governance, automation, and revenue visibility.
[LinkedIn: linkedin.com/in/tejasdhabalia](https://www.linkedin.com/in/tejasdhabalia)

Ready to close the gap?

DS Consulting provides advisory plus implementation across CRM governance, marketing automation, revenue attribution, and IBM watsonx AI for regulated enterprises.

[Contact us](#)